

Chapter 1

Leaning upon the balcony railing, the otter sighed, muzzle drooping down to his paws, fingers curled around metal. As slim as his natural kind, he grumbled to himself as flakes of black scraped off the barrier, marking his paws, yet he only held on tighter as if he would fly away if he did not hold on for dear life. He looked down and imagined tumbling to the ground, body crumpling from his first storey perch. A laugh bubbled in his throat, somewhere along the line between the sane and insane. He did not wish for death, though he wondered how far a fur would have to go to end it all.

His home was a modest one: nothing to write home about. Set about a fish and chip shop in Solihull, he could not claim it was the highlight of any city, set on the outskirts of Birmingham, England's second city. Looking down, he wrinkled his nose at the litter strewn across the car park and pavement, empty pizza boxes betraying what the fitness folks really got up to after downing vitamin smoothies at the *Furtime Fitness* cafe. The otter shook his head. His eyes locked upon the more appealing target of the ice hockey rink, a stone's throw from his home and a mere stretch of tarmac away.

It was why he watched as he did, every Thursday night without fail, for the ice hockey team to leave practice at the rink. A battered, immaculately clean pair of skates rested beside his booted hind paws, laces loosely tied together and ready to go. A gift from his parents a few years ago, he had almost used them beyond their lifespan, though he had no idea how he would afford a brand new pair. Perhaps that online auction site? He licked his lips, struggling to follow his own train of thought – his mind moved too swiftly for him to keep up with it at times.

There were no public sessions on Thursday nights, but working at the rink allowed the otter the perk of skating after hours for free, as long as all was locked up behind him and he was not alone. They were easy rules to follow and he adhered to them gladly for all the ice time he could achieve. Having skated since he could ride a bike, and finding skating more suited to his sinuous, whippy form, he took every opportunity presented to practice at that which was offered to him.

Besides, it was free. And free was always good.

His tail thumped against his jean clad calves: the players emerged in a bustle of activity. They laughed as they strode into the late summer sunshine in groups of two and three, fur matted with sweat and bags large enough to hide a body within slung over their shoulders. The otter's eyes narrowed, watching, and he stepped back into the shadows, hugging his arms around himself. British summers were such a pain; the shade was too cool for his thin fur. Kyle didn't have him work the nights of hockey games or practices, citing that the guys were 'hard to handle', time and time again. He didn't see what was so bad about the lads, but kept his distance respectfully whenever they frequented the rink. It was not his ice time anyway and it was bad form to rush a paying client off the ice.

It was silly to shrink away but the otter kept himself well out of sight until all players disappeared into their cars, shouted farewells and laughter vanishing on the wind. The otter's eyes widened, creasing at the corners, and a smile brightened his muzzle. They were gone! Now, who was working tonight? It had to be Kyle, it just had to be. Kyle would let him on the ice, that old fox. He knew he had nothing to worry about with the otter. He bounced from

hind paw to paw, excitement driving his body into a jig. Would he have much time on the ice before the zamboni came out?

He streaked down the concrete steps, coughing into his shoulder at the ever present stench of greasy fish and chips. At least his flat did not reek of it – that was one thing to be thankful for. Well, it did not smell all that often. Sometimes, only sometimes. He shook himself from the thought and hummed a tune that he had heard on the radio as he crossed the car park on light paws. Shading his eyes from the lowering sun, he raised a paw to the glass door at the front of the orange brick building, a canopy protecting the entrance from weather that was not present. It was a good little shelter from rain and for the smokers when necessary, though the otter did not like stumbling through a cloud of smoke.

Grinning, he pushed the door inward, eager to feel a more welcome chill upon his fur while his muscle thrummed with warmth, blood pumping. Skating was addictive.

“Why were you watching my team?”

The otter spun on his heel, thick tail slapping his leg audibly. One of the ice hockey players, a grey wolf with a creamy tone to his fur, stood with his arms crossed boldly across his broad chest, impossible wide. The tips of his fur were darker, black to grey, with lighter, creamier base hairs, the markings upon his face entirely unique if a fur pattern scan was taken, black whorls an identifying feature. Frowning, he shrugged his bag more comfortably upon his shoulder, a black and red jersey draped across his frame to support a team that the otter had never heard of.

Swallowing, the otter withdrew his paws from the door.

One on one, he thought. Could be worse... No need to over react now, just take it easy. Don't worry.

“Just waiting,” he answered curtly, standing up tall.

He was an inch taller than the wolf, though the canine was far more muscular than lanky, making the size difference lean in the wolf's favour. The otter hit the inside of his cheek, drawing a drop of blood. The wolf was all brute strength and power, dwarfing the otter in his shadow.

The wolf scoffed.

“Every time we have practice? Waiting?” He laughed without humour. “Why? What for? Lousy tactic if you're trying to get inside information.”

“What? Of course not, what the hell are you on about? I'm just bloody waiting to skate, you idiot!”

A pair of black ears pricked.

“Skate? Public session is closed, we're the last ones tonight. Try another.”

Sighing, the otter slid his gaze away. He was already tired and his nerves were frayed. Why couldn't he just go into the damn rink?

"Well, what *information* do you think I'm going to get from you and *your* team?" The otter snorted. "Tad paranoid, don't you think?"

Stiffening, even the wolf's tail was still.

"What's your name?"

"Why do you want to know?"

Grunting, the hockey player rolled his eyes.

"A name can't be that hard to give."

Avoiding eye contact, the otter staunchly refused to answer, nerves making his muscle tremble. He clamped his paws around his biceps, woefully small, to conceal the shaking and cursed himself inwardly. He just had to stay calm, that was all he had to do.

Watching every moment of this, the wolf was nonplussed. The tension left his tail and it returned to a faint wag – a canine attempt at friendliness. Barking a laugh, his shoulders relaxed as his tongue lolled from his muzzle.

"You're a strange one. I'm Darren, if that makes any difference."

The otter sighed. What did it matter?

"Liam," he conceded grudgingly, hefting his skates over one arm where they dangled by the laces, knots pulled taut.

Darren tilted his head to one side, appearing thoughtful. On any other fur – a smaller anthro – Liam was sure it would have been cute.

"Odd accent. You're not from Brum, are you?"

Liam rolled his eyes, mimicking the wolf's earlier action.

"Nope."

"Where then?" Darren persisted.

Casting a sidelong look into the rink, which was just visible through a window in the interior doors, Liam heaved a sigh, the exhalation catching the wolf's attention. It was too late: the zamboni rumbled around the rink, taking off a layer of ice and depositing the next coating of water, which would freeze in a few seconds. It was a bitch to skate on.

Fuck...

“You don’t half ask a lot of questions,” Liam said, surprised by the intensity behind the wolf’s brown eyes.

He shrugged, the action too casual for Liam’s liking. He should have been taking things more seriously, not making light of the situation.

“Salesfur problem. I like to get people talking as much as I like to talk. You’d be amazed what people will say if only you have listening ears.”

Darren grinned, showing a flash of teeth that were too white to be natural.

“Aren’t you going on the ice then?” He jerked his head towards the rink. “How do you get on this late? Must cost a fucking fortune for yourself.”

“I *work* there.”

Liam’s lips turned down and he glanced skyward. The light was fading, all too swift for the end of summer. Soon, it would be winter again and he would bundle himself up in a holey coat that never quite kept him warm when out and about. His lips twisted.

“Got to go. Guess it was nice meeting you.” He tried not to roll his eyes for a second time, though his tone conveyed far more than his expression. “I guess.”

As he turned away from the rink, the wolf stepped into his path, forehead creasing in confusion.

“You’re not skating anymore?”

“Zamboni’s out,” Liam raised his paws, shoulders rolling back. “What can I do?”

The wolf scratched his shoulder, ears drooping to the sides of his head. Sighing, Liam crossed his arms, wincing as his skates knocked into his stomach, blade covers thankfully preventing any injury. Though those would need replacing soon – the stitching was coming loose. Again.

“Well...sorry about that,” Darren said quietly yet clearly. “Didn’t mean to.”

Liam flushed hot with anger, the sudden rush coming over him like the nausea others felt after receiving an injection. Just who did this wolf think he was, sauntering around with his hockey bag and bluster? Why, he was all hot air with nothing to say? The otter scowled darkly. If the wolf hadn’t made him late, held him up, he could have been on the ice right now. What a bloody waste of time.

This was why he had not wanted to encounter anyone who got his back up. There was something about certain furs, their arrogant ways and attitude of getting everything they wanted and more, that riled him up to no end. Focusing on a spot of dirt on the ground, mud left by someone’s shoe, Liam focused on breathing slowly and deeply, beating down the anxiety that made his heart pound as if running a race. His palms were slippery with sweat and he uncurled his paws. He had not even realised they had formed into fists, shaking with restrained emotion. He’d had enough. Why did everyone else think they could do whatever the hell they wanted?

That was going to change.

Shifting his weight from hind paw to paw, the wolf cleared his throat, made awkward in the presence of Liam's silence.

"Is something wrong?"

He blinked, appearing for a moment almost so naive that Liam felt a flash of guilt for taking it out on him. Really, the wolf did not know any better. He could not blame him, not truly. Yet he was the one who had taken the one scrap of joy out of his day.

"Nothing."

Liam's lips pressed into a hard, thin line.

"Nothing is wrong. I never cared about your team. Just get out of my way."

Stunned, Darren did not react as Liam shoved past, ramming into the wolf's shoulder. His arm stung viciously from the impact but he was too wound up to care, needless adrenaline pumping through his veins. All he wanted to do was to skate. He just wanted some fun. Was that too much to ask?

Apparently so.

Leaving the wolf lost for words, he stormed into the rink and slammed both sets of doors behind him with a crash. It did not matter what impression he left at his heels. If he was lucky, he would never see the interfering canine again. And, if he was even luckier, Kyle would still let him on the ice for a bit.

The problem was, he had not had much good luck of late.